

One Mans Opinion

By

VaShawn F. Head

Book of poems & stories

By

VaShawn F. Head

Table of Contents

Earth Angel

What You Are

My Queen

A Distant Love

Love and the New Beginning

My Brother

Understanding

Perception

What is Age

Little Tommy Death

Darkness of Solitude

Half a Man

Inspiration

Earthly Angel

It can be said that I have searched for that elusive angel.
Never being able to find that one real angel with her wings.
I have found the beauty and sometimes even the grace,
but I have yet to find the total angelic essence that makes a
lady an angel.
It has eluded me with great perplexity. Were my expectations too
whimsical?
Were my desires too great? Were 'Earthly Angels' only a myth.
Then on a cold winter's night you appeared. Your voice soft and melodic,
like the song of a harp dancing on the back of a breeze.
The thought of you, I must admit, continued even after you disappeared
into the night.
I knew not why.
I had met beauty so captivating, so elusive before, and yet something
about you tugged at my heart strings.
Then we spoke again and the sound of your voice became intoxicating.
Like an addictive drug. Yes it had to be an' Earthly Angel'.
But alas fate, as it has often done, has played yet another cruel joke.
For although an Earthly Angel has been found, as quickly as I found her
she intends to leave.
I wish there were some way the Heavens would extend our togetherness.
But I will bask in the time she gives, and I guess be thankful she has
proven
the myths are in fact truths.
{There are earthly angels}

Devlyn 9/25/99

What You Are

Your beauty descends from the goddess, Athena herself.

Your kiss erupts every emotion inside of me.

Your caress causes time to stand still.

Your love makes all things look peaceful and serene.

For you are the world to me.

When I'm alone, I constantly think of you.

Do you do the same too?

You know you really do scare me,

For my heart is yours and if you leave me,

It too, would be left empty!

So loving you have brought me joy and happiness.

Wanting you has brought to me peace of mind.

All these things you have done to me.

So please don't stop, but rather always be mine.

My Queen

Precious is the sound of her voice.

Laugh in my ears like the soft chimes of a music box.

She is life in its rarest form, bold, beautiful, and to some over bearing.

But what I've seen, she is simply royalty, for she is a lady.

To her; I am a black knight, bowing to her majesty, her grace, her poise, her sweetness, like honey from the bee.

If life were a fairy tale, she surely would be a queen every knight would risk his life to be near.

A Distant Love

There I stood looking into the distant void, as the wind blew and the rain poured down. All that I had known forsake me. No hope left, no dreams remained. The storm crashed down upon me and the thunder roared its judgment. I agreed, standing in dismay. It spoke words in my ears as it continued to pound. There was nothingness in my heart. In this world, I had chiseled out a bleak existence.

I arose from under the tree, where, I sat receiving my sentence. I began to walk toward the edge, toward the end of my reality. Then off in the distance a figure appeared. It seemed to float over the once fierce lake, now calm as a sleeping child.

As the figure came closer, the rain slow and the wind suddenly became a breeze. The voice of the thunder had now fallen silent. There should have been fear in my heart, but I admit I had thought only of dreaming the vision that had appeared. It now stood before me. The figure I made out to be the most beautiful creature God could have ever created. This, in my mind, I had no doubt.

The rain fell like tears upon her soft glowing face, as she reached out her hand to wipe my tears away. She placed her hand in mine and led me back to the tree. She did not speak, but I heard her every thought. In my heart, her words brought peace. She caressed my face as she placed her lips against mine. She then pulled us down to our knees, then to our sides.

I stared at her in confusion and asked, "What is your name?" She did not reply. She simply kissed me again. As I gazed into her eyes, I became lost in what seemed to be paradise. I knew the thunder had lied; a dream remained. It had been hidden in my soul, underneath all the pain.

We clung to each other in passion undenied. I was lost in her love, my feelings I could not hide. She shared with me her warmth, her love, and her life. We had shared something uncontrollable, sincere and a way of life lost to man for centuries.

Two people we were, though she an angel in my mind. She brought forth a new outlook on reality. Then we held each other close and we gazed at the stars. The sky had cleared; the storm was no more.

We must have drifted off to sleep. It would not have been hard to do. Tranquility wrapped around us like a blanket through the night. I opened my eyes to smile at my love, to speak softly to her and again ask her name. But to my sorrow, she had already gone. All that lay at my side was a letter and a pen. As I read the letter, a tear seemed to form. No not of sorrow. No not to mourn.

The tear was of happiness. Why, you might ask? To explain I'll read the letter aloud.

Love Everlasting

To truly love someone is to love forever.

For forever is how long love can last.

Though memories may fade, mostly pain

and hurt of the past

The good times of love, joy and happiness

remain and last.

Like the rose a symbol of love, standing the

test of time.

So to can the love we share, and the love you

give to me forever mine.

Don't fret thinking because we are apart,

I've forgotten that love.

No, it dwells deep in my heart.

Right next to my love for life, and even mankind.

It will forever stay there and yes even climb.

Climb to new heights and travel far and wide.

Your love gives me eternal bliss, this can not be

denied.

You are compassion complete, the passion we share

no other will know.

I am devoted to you, my mind, body and soul.

These things I have no doubt, and proclaim out loud.

You ask "How do I know?" I answer and now vow.

LOVE AND THE NEW BEGINNING

The war ended in 2179, with the continents making a treaty of peace, but the war had taken its toll on the world. Wildlife had all but become extinct, for the forests and natural terrain had become tainted with the technology of the war. This became a global concern, for with these come, so to were the resources of food and water; something that politicians overlooked but the people trying to have an existence were far too familiar with. This concern started a movement through out all the continental governments, for new technology, and fast! It was agreed that this would have to come from an intense modification of the educational systems; for the scientists of the world were few, most loosing there lives in the random bombings of the war.

The search began, the search for children who showed any kind of promise to the cause. Jacqueline was one of those children found, and at the age of seven her and her family were moved to the city of New Cleveland; one of the cities developed for this purpose.

Growing up in this environment was strenuous and strict, and Jacqueline developed a conservative posture as far as dressing and life style. Education was her world, her life, the only concern she seemed to let surface as far as her true being.

But in 2183 with things beginning to change for the better so to did the flow of power. With this flow of new power came a new menace of segregation. Those who had not been chosen fell even lower in importance, and the cry for this injustice went unheard. In December 2183 an uprising occurred. The people living outside the cities were tired of the promises to one day be moved into the cities; a new war had begun. Attacks on cities were brutal and by the year 2194, the damage on the cities had become severe and martial law was enforced.

This was the year before Jacqueline faced going to the University of New Cleveland. Her priorities began to change for every day on the Viacom link, the number of deaths of what now was referred to as People's Rebellion was constant. Her eyes opened to realizing that the world she lived in was crumbling; and the misfortunate she thought were few in numbers were the majority. Yet, what could she do? It was too much for her to change; the best thing was to continue her life as it was. The following year she entered school as planned. This is when her life and beliefs would change forever.

Her first few weeks in this environment were routine, a routine she had followed for years; go to her classes and proceed home before curfew. But fate was about to step in; and she bumped into a young man named Devonte White. "Smile it'll get better." He said to her as she passed. "What will get better?" She asked. "What ever has you looking so angry." He responded. She flashed an ever so slight smile and went on her way. As weeks went on the coincidental bumping into each other increased; for little did she know Devonte followed her to every class she took. Each encounters basically the same. To some degree he began to annoy her with constant accidental encounter. She thought him some what cute, but very full of himself.

Finally the day came when Devonte asked to see her or talk with her on the phone link. Before she realized it, she had given her phone link code, and he was on his way smiling from ear to ear. "Why did I do that?" She thought to herself; and continued on her way. A week went by of not hearing from him, and she went on a trip to visit another

university in New Texas. However, she found her thoughts turned toward Devonte. She began to she actually missed him, much to her surprise.

Two weeks had passed before she returned to New Cleveland and she could not wait to see him. When they did finally see each other he was somewhat upset. “Why did you give me the wrong code? If you really didn’t want to talk to me you should have said no. I called the day you gave it to me and I was told you didn’t live there. I kept trying all week.” But I gave you the right code! and she proceeded to say the number again. She explained how her family was and that they were very protective of her. So they made arrangements to spend time at the university, and that’s just what they did. Their friendship grew into a love affair; even with world around them in chaos, they managed to find each other.

This went on for six months, but Devonte had become troubled; his insides eating at him, and Jacqueline had begun to notice. He decided it was time to tell her. Since they had decided to meet in the regeneration room on campus and have a picnic for their six month anniversary, that was as good of a time as any.

The couple met as planned, but Devonte was distant and half way through the picnic Jacqueline spoke up. “What is the matter, Devonte? I thought you’d be happy to celebrate our anniversary, but it’s like your not even here.” “No Jackie it’s not that.” Devonte replied as he turned to hold her hands. “Ok you know I love you with all my heart.” “Yes”. she answered now very concerned. “And you know how I feel about the way things are going between the alliance and the rebellion.” Yes you talk about it all the time. What has happened Devonte?” she asked in a panic. “They approached me about a month ago. I found out there are others on campus who feel the way I do and heard me talking. I went

with them to a meeting and got a chance to speak with some of their leaders. After doing so I understand more and joined.”

“You did what? What did you do that for you know the law! And what help can you be to them anyway?” Jacqueline was now standing in horror. The man she loved and thought she knew had joined rebel forces, had made her an accomplice by telling her. What was she to do now; by law anyone knowing a rebel was to report him or her. As far as she knew rebel and alliance citizens did not interact with each other. They hated each other; rebels hated the citizens for living away from the disease and misery outside the city, and citizens hated the rebels for trying to destroy their city and force that misery on them.

“Please Jackie let me explain.” Devonte reached up to her as she knelt back down by his side. He began to explain how the others just sympathized with the cause, but because of his governmental education and recent appointment to the Lobbyist of Governmental Congress of New Cleveland, they thought maybe he could make a change. “Sweetheart you know the lobbyist position is the first step into political power, and only ten are chosen to train to one day replace the congressional members. Never before have they ever had this chance. Maybe with the bloodshed can stop and a peaceful solution come about.”

Jacqueline stared at Devonte for sometime; to him those minutes seemed like years. He had put his heart, his future, yes even his life into her hands; then the silence was broken.

“This is what you want?” she said with a stern look on her face. Devonte nodded slowly, “Then how can I help?” she said with a smile. Devonte let out a sigh of relief.

“There’s a meeting in two days, come with me and choose for yourself.” Jacqueline agreed, why not that was the day he would also meet her family.

He arrived at her house at 8:00 p.m. promptly; and after borage of questions from her mom and sisters, was allowed to leave with Jacqueline.

After a long ride, they finally arrived at the designated place. They were met by guard and Devonte gave what Jacqueline figured was a pass word and they were escorted in. As she walked with Devonte and the guards she saw the wounded and starving, she realized she had walked into their world of reality. Just then she was brought back from her thoughts by a little boy holding a beaten up toy. "Gee your pretty." Jacqueline stooped down and began moving the boy's hair out of his face. "and you're quite handsome." Suddenly she heard Devonte call to her and she stood up and said goodbye. The meeting began and Jacqueline listened to the words spoken, but in the back of her mind that little boy and all the people she had seen struck strongly. She knew what she had to do now.

After returning home she spoke with her mother about she knew interest in medicine. Seeing her daughter strong convictions in the matter she simply told her to follow her heart. The next day she returned to campus a new woman and changed her courses to the field of medicine.

As time went on Jacqueline returned to where she met the little boy and used what ever she was learning to aid the wounded and sick. She began to teach the children taking special interest in her new little friend.

Twelve years have passed, the year is now 2207. Devonte in those twelve years took the world by storm. He toured around the globe, ever so sublte changing the way rebels and citizens viewed each other. He gained the people's trust and 2203 became President of the Northern Continent.

Jacqueline is considered the finest doctor in the world to date. She broke the boundaries that citizen doctors should not help rebel wounded and sickly in 2201. She was contested by many, but with Devonte's new bill being passed and her never giving in it came to be.

Did I mention that the two were married? Oh, sorry, Yes, they were married August 29, 2200. They vowed that until the world had changed for the better they would never bring a child into it. They strived for better programs to help everyone and never gave up.

As I said earlier, the date is August 29, 2207. The world is at peace. Food is plentiful; the water, crystal clear, and although the wildlife has evolved differently from what I remember, never the less, it is abundant as well. The two changed the world and kept there promise to each other. Today Devonte, Jr. was born.

You may wonder who I am. Well I'm a beneficiary of the program those two started. I'm studying to be a historian. To make sure we never go back to that time. I'm also the little boy Jacqueline spoke to all those years ago. My name is Michael Gordan the V, but that's another story...

The End

By

VaShawn F. Head

My Brother

My brother, I hear you say.

But I wonder if you know the trials and tribulations that I go through everyday.

When I arise the sun looks different through my eyes.

I see the day as a part of a never ending struggle, while you see the day as a new opportunity in life.

I must remember my heritage, and the prejudice it begot and you try hard to remember it not.

I see the poverty and destitute all around and you continuously try tear these down; to make your shopping centers and malls galore; which makes me search for another place to soar

Soar above the poverty and degradation you have set for me.

So the next time when you try to say you understand think first,

MY BROTHER

Understanding

Caught in the turmoil of the heart and mind.

Always thinking love is unkind

Then you meet someone like me

For I am for you, your destiny

But there is another who holds you true

You sit and ponder what to do

For this one holds you tight suffocation indeed

You think the other holds you with love a warmth that you need

But in truth, you know he puts fear in your heart

You want to tell me to depart.

I say to you, if this is what you want, then this is what I'll do.

But the way you feel for me won't leave you.

And when you are with him you will want me,

So please reconsider and be with me.

But if not I understand!

Perception

Good evening. I pose these questions for you. What is reality? Does how we perceive things determine reality from fantasy. Is one man's reality another man's nightmare? Or does the populace determine reality? See If this little story will change your mind.

The time is the present. In a small project on the Lower East Side of Cleveland. Two teenagers stand in front of a run down neighborhood store. Across the street they look on the first floor of a run down apartment building to see the last of the Mohicans. One of the teenagers begin to speak.

"Yo, yo man." He begins with a smirk. "Look at him over there. He looks ill just sitting there, staring out into nothing." "Tell me about it," the other responds as he opens a bag of chips. "The last of the Mohicans. Or in this case the last of the pale faces." "At least in this hood," the other jokes back. "Yeah, and have you seen him. They say for a quarter he'll show his nubs for legs, and do tricks with his wheelchair."

He hears them as they begin to walk away. Lets cross the street and meet this odd little man. His name is Robert R Comings, he was a Sergeant in the Marines in Desert Storm, he was one of the so called wounded. I wonder if those wounded ever think of themselves as few. Oh well, back to Robert, he got the Purple Heart for loosing his legs.

As he sits by the window we look into his mind to remember that time: Somewhere in the Middle East, in a foxhole, a bombardment of shellings is going on, soldiers are dug in. A soldier with lieutenant stripes begins to speak into the radio, "This is Delta Squad, calling Mother Hen, we are pinned in. Taking heavy artillery. Request air support, or evac." "Delta Squad, hold position, air support E.T.A. 30 minutes, hold position until then." "Roger." The lieutenant throws the radio down. "Shit, 30 minutes, we won't last 3 minutes in this shit hole." One of the soldiers snap. "Hell man I don't want to die here, I am getting the hell out of here."

He jumps up and starts running up over the sand hill, the lieutenant hollers out "Datson get your ass back here or I'll shoot you myself." As he begins to take aim.

"No lieutenant," Robert grabs his arm. "I'll get him." Datson is walking up the hill in a daze, Robert catches up to him with ease and tackles him. Datson begins to babble, "I don't want to die sarge, I am to young to die." "Hey I am only 23, you won't die" Roberts responds. "I won't be giving that order today, now lets head back." But Datson is to afraid to move, so Robert picks him up and carries him.

Just as they approach they're squad position, Robert hears the lieutenant holler, "Incoming!" He hears the shells loud scream, then darkness.

Robert awakes in a hospital with a scream, "Where am I?" he hollers. A nurse rushes to his side. "You're safe now, you're in a hospital, soldier your going home." "Home? What happened? Where's Datson?" "Who? Oh the guy that came in with you, just a few scratches, but he will be fine. Your lieutenant says you saved him. You on the other hand, your heart stopped twice. We couldn't let a hero die now could we." "It will take a lot more than that to kill me." He reaches to hold his head. "You need to take an easy, the doctor will be right with you," the nurse replies softly. "Oh my head, I just need to sit up," then the horror hits him, he screams "My legs!!!"

Back to the present. Now he sits in his roach infested, four brick walls of gloom; staring at the only thing he finds beautiful in his environment.

Her name is Bonita, but her friends call her Precious. Robert stares at her, longing to hold her, to be with her, swearing that he fell for her the first time he laid eyes on her. Now he watches her across the street in the parking lot of the store, selling that momentary escape from reality, white death and crack cocaine. About ten feet away from her in his car is her employer, watching her back, he calls to her.

"Hey Precious," she runs over to him, "Check it, I need to go pick up some more, I'll be right back. Sell what you got, then sit tight." "Okay, see you in a few," she answers back. He peels off.

A regular customer approaches her with someone new "Hey Precious, you holding?" "Now you know I got the bomb, how much you need?" She responds staring at the new face. The new face speaks, "Well how much do you have?" "Talk to the hand I don't know you, why you bring this with you, AND LET IT TALK TO ME. I think you should step and let us do business." She reaches out to her regular customer and steps to the side. "Hey Coco, don't be bringing no newbie's around when you want to deal with me." "I'm sorry Precious, he's my new man."

"Whatever, so what you need?" She reaches for her stash in her bra. "All of what you got bitch" The new face walks up behind her, a large caliber gun point at her head. Coco hollers "What are you doing?" "Getting what we need." He responds slightly distracted. Precious sees her chance, she thinks, "I grew up with three bothers, I ain't going out like this." She grabs for the gun and knees him in the groin, they tussle, one shot goes off. BANG! Coco falls to the ground, a second shot it fired, BANG! It echoes in Precious mind. There is a flash of fear that rushes to her heart. The gun falls, a body crashes to the ground, there is a moment of stillness. Then Precious realizes she is not the one shot. The new face lays still, blood flowing out of his motionless body. She looks over at Coco, the bullet

blowing out that back of her head, she panics as she hears the sirens in the distance. Off in the distance she also hears a voice, "Bonita, over here," she looks up to see Robert in the window across the way. "Come on the police are coming." As she runs across the street Robert hollers "Number 3." Soon there is banging at his door, he opens the door and she rushes in closing the door behind her, leaning on the door in relief.

Robert rolls backwards and sits and stares at this 21 year old goddess. She stands before him in shorts and a white shirt tied in a knot at her stomach, a black lace bra underneath but visible. "Hey, hey I said why are you helping me?" He snaps back to reality.

"You wouldn't believe me if I told you" "Yeah your probably right." "Damn, it's kinda creepy in here, all these pictures of soldier shit and models of planes and stuff. Is that what happened to you?" She turns and rally looks at him for the first time. "I'm sorry, what do you mean?" He asks puzzled. "Your legs man, is that how you lost them, in somebody elses war? She now sits down on the couch.

"Yeah a war. Seems to me you know a little about war," as he rolls over the window to look out across the street. The police have arrived with a crowd of people gathered around to see death up close and personal. He looks back at her, her head is down.

"That was pretty ballsy," he rolls over to her, sensing her still slightly trembling. "I said that was a ballsy thing you did." Huh, oh yeah, that's an everyday thing in the hood, ya know." "Yeah I know," he looked at her at with admiration at her attempt of toughness. All of a sudden there's banging at the door.

"Open up police! BANG, BANG, BANG. "Coming, coming," Robert opens the door, "Yes officer." "Ah yes may we come in?" "Certainly," Robert rolls back from the door and the officers step in. "There was a shooting across the street," Robert notices the second officer walking over to the window and staring at Bonita. "Yeah I noticed all the commotion after my aid helped me out of the bathroom." The second officer speaks, "Your aid? Since when they let aids dress like that?" "I volunteer to help him," she says with an attitude as she gets up to push Robert away from the first officer.

The second officer looks at Bonita with a serious stare, "And what would his name be?" Robert sticks his hand out to shake, "Robert R. Commings; 232 Airborne, Gulf Storm Veteran, at your service officer." The officer suspiciously reaches out to shake hands as the first officer calls to him. "Hey Harry, check this out," the officer walks over to his partner. Robert motions for Bonita to push him over to where they are standing, "Go ahead and pick it up, got that loosing these." He waves hands in front of his knees where there is just air.

"Wow Tim, will you look at all the medals," the second officer exclaims. Bonita pays attention for the first time. He turns and reaches out his hand to shake

Robert's hand with high esteem. "Well Mr. Commings, were sorry to have bothered you, take care." "You do the same officers," Bonita pushes him towards the door to escort the officers out. As Robert closes the door he hears the officers talking, "Damn sad that a vet like that has to live in a dump like this," officer Harry says. "You telling me!" answers back Tim.

"Hey I wonder what's in that locked tin under the medals," officer Harry looks at him and says, "Probably some old letters and stuff, they tend to be sentimental you know."

Bonita rolls him back over to the medals and begins admiring them herself, "So a genuine war hero, huh? Now that's pretty cool." She turns and looks at him, "Hey thanks, that was pretty cool what you just did for me I owe you big time. No body has ever stood up for me like that, not even Star." "Star? The guy in the car?" "Damn you be peeping me tight, don't you. Yeah in the car, anyway I owe you big time so if there is anything I can do for you..." "As a matter of fact there is one thing..."

A flash to the future, five years time, same area, different seen. There is construction going on now, the old graffiti ridden buildings now turned to dust and rubble.

A new model van pulls up and honks its horn at the woman in a business suit standing next to a construction foreman pointing at blue prints. In side sits Robert at the wheel, a wedding band on his finger. As the woman finishes with the foreman she turns and heads for the van.

She hops into the van, the two kiss, "I'm sorry hun that you had to come pick me up here, there's such a mixup on the sight. I had to get out here myself to see what the problem was." "Bonita, baby its okay, I'll got to hell and back for you. Hell I'd die to be with you, you are so precious to me." They kiss "You used to be Precious remember," he chuckles to himself. She hits him, "That's not funny and don't remind me." "Sorry, just kidding, besides look at what you are achieving now."

"Yeah but it will never enough for..." He puts his fingers her lips, "That's the past, time heals all wounds." She smiles, "Well lets go man, we have two beautiful girls to pick up from daycare." They begin to drive off.

We catch up to them driving down a street in the suburbs. He turns into a driveway, "Home sweet home," Robert proclaims. He has pulled up to a colonial style home with the white picket fence and the dog in the yard. The little girls jumped out of the van and ran to play with dog. Bonita stays behind to get her briefcase out. Robert sits for a minute to take the whole scene in. He opens the door, and steps out of the van, grabs one of the little girls and picks her up and reaches to take the others hand. They all walk into the house.

Now there is a scene of the four of them at dinner. After dinner Robert washes the dishes while Bonita gives the girls a bath. They both come in to tuck in the two little girls. They say prayers together then Robert and Bonita leave out closing the door behind them. Bonita reaches up to rub her neck...He massages her neck, "Well Mrs Commings you look like you need a soak. I'll go and run your bath water and Calgon and I will take you away."

She soaks peacefully in the tub with Robert behind her gently rubbing her shoulders. They share a few tender moments, which carry on out of the tub and into the bedroom. She unfastens his pants and they fall to the ground. He reaches down to unsnap his titanium prosthetic legs, "Sit down let me help you," Bonita says lovingly.

They begin to share their love. After 20 minutes and well into their passion there is a banging at the door. Robert and Bonita gather their composure and Robert pulls himself into the wheelchair kept by the bed. As he rolls towards the door the banging gets louder, "Yes, yes who is it?" "Hello open up it's the police." Robert opens the door, "Hello I'm officer Tim O'Brady, and this is officer Harry Kindle." The second officer tips his hat, "May we come in?" Robert rolls back stunned and in a haze. "We are here about the shooting across the street. Did you see or hear anything?" Robert stumbles to speak looking around for Bonita...

"Shooting?" "Ah yes sir, two African American women were shoot. One through the head and the other through in the..." "Nooooo!!" Robert cried out. He races over to the window. He peers out to see two police cars parked somewhat vertically but at a slant, between the two cars lay the bodies. He stares harder hoping and praying, and yes it is Precious his beloved Bonita as they zip the body bag. "No I didn't see or hear anything." "Are you sure?" Officer Tim asks as he looks out the window too.

"Wow Tim, will you look at all these medals," officer Tim turns and walks over to his partner. He picks up one of the medals and turns to Robert, "Wow, the Purple Heart, huh" "Yeah," is all that Robert could muster as he sits in disbelief. "Yeah well if you think of anything give us a call." Officer Harry says as he hands him a card. Robert takes it from him, as he and they make their way to the door; he makes his way over to where the medals are kept. He reaches for the locked tin box, rubs it fondly and says to himself "I'd die to be with you." As he opens the lock we see the officers walking down the hall, they began to speak to each other. "Damn sad that a vet like that has to live in a dump like this." Officer Harry says, "You are telling me!" answers back Tim. "Hey I wonder what's in that locked tin under the medals." Officer Harry looks at him and says, "Probably some old letters and stuff, they tend to be sentimental you know."

There is darkness, a sudden flash of light, and a loud explosion. Then a loud thud.

By

VaShawn F. Head

What is age

What is age, to the contrast that years bring wisdom?

I speak not against experience as the teacher of life.

But can I not be heard because my years fall short of yours.

Haven't you heard 'Out of the mouths of babes.' or is this too cliché?

Alright then hear this, 'It is not the quantity of years you live, but rather the quality you live in those years; for there are fools 20 to 100 and wise men who are 100 and some who are 20.'

So the next time when I try to speak, don't look at my age but rather instead listen to my words if not to hear, then to be respectful as you so often tell the young to do.

There is a chance you may ask yourself the very same question.

What is age?

Little Tommy Death

"Case File 10739642, I'd like to talk with you about Tommy Peters." He stood there in front of me. This guy with a news reporters eyes and blank stare like there was nothing in this world more important than a story. "What about Tommy Peters?" I replied. "Oh I'm sorry, my name is Timothy Waters, and I'm with the Herald." As if saying this brilliant introduction was suppose to impress me. He reaches his hand out to shake mine.

"Yeah o.k. I take it you know who I am other wise you wouldn't be standing here asking me about that case." I reach out to shake his hand, cold, clammy, trembling even, very light grip. When you've been a cop for as long as I had been you notice these things about people.

"Boy do I ever, you're Sergeant Charles Weatherby. At seventeen you joined the army. After serving two years, the war broke out. You did one year in Vietnam, where half your platoon was killed in an explosion when a kid came into the camp carrying a shoe shine box filled with explosives. You moved up in rank pretty fast, pretty much because the officers in your platoon seemed to be pretty expendable at times and you were the senior man. Came back to the states in 1972, immediately went to the police academy, highest in your class. You made detective faster then any person on the force; if I'm not mistaken eleven accommodations and awards, just like in 'Nam. You were the Detective who took down that serial killer, Braxton. He killed eleven college co-eds, before you caught him. But you caught him."

This kid seemed to know more about me then I cared to remember. You know what's funny is I never liked the number eleven. I just never could understand why until now. "Yeah, yeah you seem to know a lot about me. Why? Hold that thought." A customer had come in, time to go to work. "Yes mam, who are you looking for today. That would be on the third floor, door 312. No problem, that's what I'm here for." That's what I'm here for rang in my head like a sludge hammer. This kid had just run down my life history, and all my great glory and now I sat here a rent-a-cop telling old rich people where to find their brokers.

The kid was patient; I gave him that. After I returned from walking the lady to the elevators, he didn't miss a beat. "Well you see I'm new at the Herald. I was digging through old case files and I came across Case File 10739642. As I read it I got this feeling that it wasn't as cut and dry as it sounded. I could tell there was a story there." I sat back down in my chair, sizing this kid up I said, "How old are you kid?" "Who me? I'm twenty five." He seemed confused. "So you couldn't have been more then twenty-two or twenty-three when that case was going on. That case is over two years old." I thought to myself I new exactly how old that case was. I retired early because of that case. "Well actually the third year anniversary of that case is this month, that's why I went to my editor and asked to be assigned to this story. People like nostalgia." I felt uneasy answering him about this case, but mainly because with all my training there was something missing about Mr. Timothy Waters. I just couldn't put my finger on it.

My shift was about over and my replacement had come in time to clock out. The kid was relentless. "Could I buy you a cup of java or something?" He was trying so hard to be polite. Against my better judgment I said. "That might not be so bad; I know a place

on my way home I normally stop off for breakfast. You driving?" "No, I caught a ride with a friend here." You know how a person constantly smiles about everything. This Waters had that kind of disposition. But for three years I kept a lot bottled up inside about Case File 10739642, about Tommy Peters. Maybe it was time; maybe people would care to know the real story. The things I found out that made me quit.

As we road to the coffee shop I was impressed that the kid asked a few key questions to get me thinking, but he pretty much sat quiet to give me a chance to collect my thoughts. We got to the coffee shop and ordered and I began. He sat quietly and listened. "You need dates and times?" I began again. "To be honest, that kind of stuff confuses a reader. I can fill in all of that. I don't want to bog you down with that stuff, just give me the meat." He was trying to make it as easy as he could. After all it was a tough case for me. He didn't want a bunch of facts and figures, I could tell. He was looking for exactly what I needed to get off my chest after three years.

"Alright kid I'll give you what I remember, on one condition." "Anything," he perked up in his seat to listen. "You tell it like I say it, don't go glorifying anything that shouldn't be." "What ever you say," he said taking out his little pad and pencil.

So I began, "It had been about a month after the Braxton case. The captain at the time was this hard nose son of a b named Jordan. My kind of guy. Straight to the point pulled no punches. I'm at my desk and he comes up to me. "Weatherby, a call came over dispatch. An old lady, found shot twice with a .38 special it looks like. You want it?" I had been sitting on my loins from the Braxton case for a month gloating. It was time to get back to the job. "Sure, I'll take it. Who's the first man on the scene?" "Grigora, I believe and don't start any shit with him either. I ain't in the mood for you twos bullshit." "Hey Cap. It's not me you should be saying that to." "Excuse me," again Waters had that distressed look on his face. "What's the deal with Grigora and you?"

"Grigora, was this fat lazy S.O.B.," I began, "Who was way off base with the Braxton case. He thought it was some college preppy kid getting his rocks off. He was following the clues with his head stuck up his ass." "You figured out it was Professor Braxton?" he interrupted. "First, don't interrupt me. But yeah, I saw that all the girls were failing his class. The guy was weird to begin with and I had a feeling about him. Come to find out, he would proposition the girls to be with him for a passing grade. Problem was some G.I.'s had castrated him in the service. He was messing around with his commander's wife. His superior officer sanctioned the little party and covered it up. He got the money to get his education and then some. Made professor. Any way when the girls went along and saw his wiener or lack there of, needless to say their response pissed him off." I could tell Waters wanted to ask something but he sat still. I liked that.

"So anyway I get to the scene and sure enough Grigora has a few words for me." Grigora starts in on me, "So they sent the wonder boy for such a puny case?" I looked at him and said, "There's probably nothing as puny as what you got between your legs. It's a wonder you didn't figure out what was going on with Braxton, you two had so much in common." And I kept walking by him. "So who was the first officer on the scene?" I spoke up to the group of plain clothes standing in front of me. "He's over there, throwing up.

"I walked over to where I saw one of the cops doubled over, he didn't look much older then you look Waters, definitely a rookie." I patted him on the back. "You o.k. kid?" He tried to have a straight face when he answered me. "Yes sir, I'll be fine. I just never seen no body's head

blown open before.” “Give it time, you’ll see worse in that you stay on the job long enough.” “Her name is,” he began “Miss Barbara Peters. Sixty nines years old, been living here for over twenty years.”

I proceeded into the house. The usual were there, coroner, forensics, you know. “So what’s the skinny?” I asked one of them. “Looks like the old lady got it while she was sleep. Two .38 specials to the head, point blank range.” That’s when I started noticing all the Jesus pictures and statues everywhere. As I walked through the house I got this feeling that there were little things around the house that didn’t fit. As I held a little action figure in my hand I yelled, “Where’s the kid?” “What kid?” Grigora blurts out as he walks up besides me. “Fire up that old still mill you call a brain and look around. Toys here and there don’t fit with what looks like a religious granny.” I tossed the action figure over to him. “Find out if anyone else lives here, any children or grand kids. You and you,” I pointed to two plain clothes standing around. “Go talk to the neighbors, find out what you can.” As I started to walk out of the house I took the toy out of Grigora’s hand. “I’m going back to the station, Bill, he was the coroner on the scene, get with forensics and I want a report in a couple of hours. Can you do that for me?” “Sure thing!” he replied.

“Excuse me,” Waters began. “So you walked in and felt something right away.” Again with the interruptions. I let this one slide. “People laugh about gut feelings and such, but sometimes that all you got to go on; that gnawing in your side that won’t go away. So yeah I felt something right away.” “Anyway,” I said kind of annoyed, “I made it back to the station and just like I asked in a couple of hours the report came. While I waited I made some calls. Found out Miss Barbara Peters had a daughter. She had died in the local hospital. So I decided since the house would probably be cleared out by now to go back to the old girls house and really look around, undisturbed.

When I got there the place was taped off. I sat in my car and briefly looked through the report. The usual stuff, quiet lady, went to church three or four times a week. Then like a red light flashing I saw in the notes the flat foots took of the neighbors that one of them mentioned hearing a kid from time to time. No one else had ever seen a kid from the notes; this one had just heard a child from time to time. So before I went inside the Peters house I walked to talk with this neighbor. Before I could get to the door she had opened it. “You a policeman?” “Yes mam, Detective Sergeant Charles Weatherby, if I could I would like to ask you a few questions.” “Yes, yes come in, I’ll make us some tea.” As I walked through the door I began. “So how did you know Miss Peters?” I followed her to the kitchen where she began boiling water in a teakettle. “Oh I’ve known Barbie since we were kids. Grew up in the same neighborhood. Imagine my surprise when my late husband,” she stopped suddenly. “You know my husband’s name was Charles, such a nice strong name that is. Charles, kind of gives you goose bumps when you hear it.” “Thank you mam,” I tried to say it with respect but she was drifting off the subject something fierce, and I had a case to solve. “Oh, oh, I’m sorry.” I figured she got the point in the tone I used. “As I was saying imagine my surprise when my husband and I moved here and there was Barbie right down the street. She was a good Christian woman and helped me a lot when Charles died.” “Could you tell me about her daughter?”

“You mean Mary Elizabeth. Now there was a troubled child, ran away all the time, hung out with a bad crowd. She ran in and out of Barbie’s house always causing a fuss when she returned. The last time was about eleven years ago or so. Barbie told me she had gotten herself pregnant. You know I had heard she worked the streets, and did those drugs and things. Bad seed that child was. Never could understand how she could be that way with such a loving mother.

Just goes to show you no matter how much a parent tries, your child can still go bad.” She had said that like the girl was a carton of milk or something. She began pouring the tea. “Milk, sugar?” “No thank you mam. Please continue and thank you for the tea.” “It’s kind of cold today, I can feel the rain coming with these old bones. Should storm by this evening. Any who,” she smiled as she sipped her tea, “Barbie had told me Mary Elizabeth died giving birth to those babies.” “Those babies?” This made me sit up. “Yes, Barbie said she had triplets, two died and after she died there was some kind of mix up and that baby wound up going for adoption or some such thing. It hurt her so that she had a grand child out there and she didn’t know what happened to it.” “So you’re saying she never found the child, but in my report it states you said you heard a child from time to time.” Yes that is true, I used to ask Barbie about that, but it would make her so upset to have to remember about the grandchild she never could get to know. I figured it was sounds from the near by playground carried on the wind or these old ears were just hearing things.” “So why did you mention it to the officers that visited you.” “Well, he had asked me about children just like you did, and mention toys in the house. Asked if any of the neighbor kids could have went there. Barbie was a sweet person, but she never let anyone in her house. She has a vast collection of religious statues from all over the world she said, even from the Vatican.” I drank some of the raspberry tea she had made and thanked her for her time. As I walked out her front door I asked her, “How long have you been living here?” “Charles and I moved back to the old neighborhood three years ago. Barbie’s been here since we were kids.”

That gnawing feeling had now turned to pain. Just then I noticed Waters hadn’t written any of this down so I spoke on it. “You got one of them photographic memories or something?” “I don’t understand,” he replied. “You haven’t wrote not one word.” “Oh! I was caught up sorry.” and he picked up his pad and scribbled some notes. “So,” I continued, “I went back to the Peters house and looked around. I found a few more toys scatted throughout the house and decided to head for the basement. Typical basement, storage area, and shelves with jars of jelly she made herself and other canned goods. Nothing unusual, so I started back up the stairs and turned the light out on the landing when I looked back and saw a light under what appeared to be a brick wall. I felt around the wall and moved a crucifix hanging there and the wall opened.” “And, and,” Waters seemed impatient. “And it was a child’s room.” “How you know?” he was hanging on my every word. “You mean aside from children’s clothes all over and some more toys in a toy box.” I stated sarcastically. “I fumbled through what I found when I looked up and in a dark corner hung a huge crucifix with leather straps for the arms and a little ledge for the feet. A whip hung off to the side on the wall. With closer observation I found fresh and dried blood. I took samples of it and was about to head back to the station when a double homicide with a .38 special came across the squawk box at Wallaby Elementary School about four blocks away. I hit my siren and speed over there.

As I pulled up Grigora was there, before he could speak I said, “Damn, the trail of doughnuts lead you here too.” and I kept on walking. Bill was on site again, so I approached him, “What we got now?” “Follow me.” We proceeded to an obscure area behind the school in the woods. As we approached the bodies I looked over and saw a little girl with a police jacket over her shoulder. She couldn’t have been more than ten or eleven. There’s that damn eleven again. “Who’s first on the scene,” I look over and there’s the rookie doubled over again. “Not him again!!” I bellowed. As if in a glee club the remaining officers said together, “Yes, him again.” I walked over to the kid, “You must have fast response times rookie.” “I want to make detective sir, but three in one day.” “Well when you do you shouldn’t have anything left to throw up.” my subtle attempt at humor. One of the other officers walked up to me and flipped his pad up and

started reading. "The man's name is Adam Brody," as he began I heard a scream come from Grigora and he dropped to his knees, the officer continued. "The boys name is Bobby Grigora, Grigora's grandson." I went into action, "Get him out of here. Cover those body's up this is a crime scene damn it." For the first time I felt something for Grigora other then contempt. As I saw then pull him from his grandson and help him up and away from the scene, I asked the officer, "And what about the girl what's her story."

"Well sir, Adam Brody is a English teacher here, from talking with the other kids Bobby Grigora is the school bully. The little girl's name is Melanie Morales. She says Brody and Grigora were about to play a game with her when some kid she had never seen before walked up to both of them and shot them; Brody in the head and Grigora in the back when he tried to run. He took off running into the woods." "Anyone else know about THIS GAME that was about to be played." "That's all I could get out of her for now. She's pretty shook up, sir." "Yeah thanks. Bill is it our same shooter." "Can't tell of course 'till I run some test but it is definitely the same caliber." "Hey they got a report of some kid at a playground with some ice cream and a gun over on West Blvd." "West Blvd. that's by the Peters house. Shit Grigora!!!" I belted out of there like a bat out of hell. Neither the rookie nor anyone else would be first this time. As I speed over there that gnawing pain was ripping through me. So much was missing; I knew it was but if Grigora got the same call...

When I got there Grigora was on the ground with a kid, still holding his ice cream in one hand and a gun in the other pointing at Grigora's head. "Officer down, officer down." As I approach Grigora was shot in the stomach his gun laid at his side. "There all bad people, really bad people," the child began as he licked his ice cream cone with tears streaming down his eyes.

"You're right. Absolutely right and you had to punish them. But now I'm here and I can help you if you let me. Tell me why you did what you did." Just then other units arrived I signaled them to stand down and give me a chance.

"Grandma, always punishing because mommy was bad and she didn't want God to judge her anymore for what her family did. She couldn't get into Heaven unless I repented for my and mommy's sins." "Did she beat, I mean punish you today?" I slowly moved toward the boy with my hand on my gun. "Yes, today was a good day for every body to go to Heaven, don't you think." He looked at me still pointing the gun at Grigora's head. "Tommy Peters, no Tommy Death, like the Angel of Death. After grandma cleansed me of my sins today, I went and got the gun I had found had hidden mommy's room a long time ago. I don't know if grandma even knew it was there. Grandma kept a lot of mommy's things just to remind me of how terrible she was." "So you sent grandma to Heaven?" I had gone about as close as I thought I could get without distracting him too much. "And the others?" "Mr. Brody had this game he used to play with me called house. Bobby used to bully me and make me play with Mr. Brody. When grandma found out she took me away from school and said I was following in my mother's footsteps in being a deviant and a whore. Mr. Brody played house with a lot of kids. Did you know he went to grandma's church? She would let him watch and take pictures of her cleansing me and he would give her money." My stomach turned now, I felt for the kid and all I wanted to do was stop his pain.

"They're all bad people, and I don't want to be cleansed any more." "No..." I screamed as he pulled the trigger while he stood over Grigora, my instincts kicked in and I pulled my gun and fired. One shot through the heart. As I approached the now still little boy still holding his ice cream, Grigora laid there with a bullet right between the eyes. How pointless it all was. "That's when you quit?" Waters, I had forgotten he was even there. "No not right away. The case was

closed but not wrapped up. The autopsy showed that Tommy had massive scar tissue all over his body, even his privates. The blood sample I took was his blood and it was fresh. After going through Adam Brody's house we found hundreds of pictures of kids with Bobby 'playing house' and the pictures of Tommy hanging on the cross being whipped. Bank statements showed he paid for most of Barbara Peter's bills. Hush money probably and he had someone to share in his twisted warped diseased antics. Plenty of kids after Brody's death started talking about what he had done to them with Bobby's help. I guess Bobby was his apprentice.

"None of this ever made it to the press?" Water seemed shocked. "You see three years ago there was a different kind of politics going on in this fair city. A cop's grandson being at the center of a sadistic triple homicide, that would be bad for the force, the community, the mayor. No this was settled out of court. The families compensated generously, and Tommy Peters became Tommy Death; a sick warped little kid that went crazy one day for no apparent reason. But you see Tommy wasn't the cause, they were the cause. "They, you mean the people he killed?" Waters seemed surprised at my statement. "Yeah Waters, them and all those that covered it up. They were the cause; Tommy was their creation, like Frankenstein and he refused to be hidden any more. That's when I quit. Like that rookie my stomach turned and I couldn't take any more of it. But you'll never get the real story out"

"Man oh man. Thanks I knew there was more to it then I had already found out. And you might be surprised, like you said the politics were different back then. Times change." "Hey it's closing time you guys, I got to lock up now," the waitress said. Man the whole day had gone by. As Waters and I got up I asked him if he needed a ride. He agreed. He led me to a ritzy part of town. As I pulled into the driveway, which seemed to take forever to get to the house, I mean mansion I asked, "Whose house is this?" Water replied "My parents." "And just who are your parents?" "Well you would probably know my father as Walter Wiggins Waters the third, news tycoon and multi-millionaire. He bought the Herald two years ago. When this story hits I'll make sure you get a copy. Promise!!!!" "Hey how did you find me?" I hadn't up to this point even thought to ask. "A good reporter never gives up his sources, you know that detective!" and he winked at me.

As he jumped out of my car and I drove off, I wondered if I had done the right thing. One thing was for sure I felt better then I had felt since it had all happened. A few days had passed and I awoke to my phone ringing. "Hello," I said half sleep. "Well hello, is this Charles Weatherby. This is the mayor," he continued before I could answer. "Look Weatherby, there's been a cover up that I was not privy too, I assure you and well anyway there are going to be some changes at the district you came from. How would you like your old job back?" "Well..." "O.k. how about a promotion?" "As I was about to say mayor..." "Let's not waste time you're the kind of officer that should be over there, so how about you running the place?" "You mean captain?" "That's right Captain Weatherby, see you in my office in, let's say two hours is that enough time?" "Yeah sure I'll be there, but just to talk I am not saying I take the job." "Fine, fine two hours." the mayor hung up.

Before I could sit up, the phone rang again. "Hey Weatherby, Tim Waters. Left something for you on your front door. Hope you don't mind. See ya around and I hope you like the story." We hung up and I made my way out of bed to my front porch. There was a note attached to the newspaper. It seems Timothy Waters had a little brother, an adopted little brother who was fourteen and at that age for the last two years of wanting to know his real family. Walter Wiggins Waters the third traced little Richie, back to our humble town. But when he began to pry, doors quickly closed. The Herald was in financial trouble and he bought it to put roots down

until he could find the answers his son needed. His oldest son Timothy Waters also took on the task and for the last two years dug until he dug me up. He couldn't go back to his baby brother with the garbage he had found. I had nothing to loose and he knew it. I went from the letter to the newspaper. The headline read 'TOMMY DEATH: THE TRUE TRAGIC STORY OF A MONSTER SOCIETY CREATED.' Catchy title, the story pretty much stuck to the facts that I had given. It also mentioned some proof Waters had uncovered, apparently there were three babies born. But instead of just one making it, two had survived, and it was the grandmother that took one of them and put the other up for adoption. I went on to read that the article pretty much made me out to be the misunderstood sheriff that was run out of town when the townsfolk were through with him.

Three years I had that little boy's death haunt me, being as low key as I could just to deal with my self. Now the truth was out and every one knew it. I was about to talk with the new mayor and get my badge back. All because of a little boy people called Tommy Death. An unfortunate I knew as eleven year old Tommy Peters.

Darkness of Solitude

They say time heals all wounds, but how can it heal that which is constant.

My heart weighs heavy like a black hole excerpting all that thought I was; gradually pulling what little fight I have left, into its' cold black center.

I feel alone and I know I am surrounded by others, yet alone I stand, alone I have this darkness, alone I am slowly dying.

I fight to allow time to heal these wounds that bleed emotions and not cells of the flesh, but at every turn, my heart is dampened with more darkness, sadness and pain the wounds continue to bleed.

I stand before you beaten, cold and tired.

The void I fear will win, I have little fight left in me.

If it does there will be nothing but time.

I will drift in the darkness that has become my heart; there swallowed;

I will forever stand alone.

Half the Man

Good day. Although I feel that my name, time and place are irrelevant to what I have to say I will give this information for argument sake. My name is Jonathan Morrow. I have walked this plain since the days of Columbus. I lived in a small providence called Chesapeake Bay, **outside of what you now know as Boston**. You think you have heard of it, yes? I assure you have not, for your historians would surely argue the existence of the place in your timeline, due to the tragedy that occurred. Evil befell my providence, my life, and my love.

You see I was a man who put faith in science, not religion. This would have made me an outcast. I dare say it would have had me burned at the stake, to speak such blasphemy outwardly as is spoken today in your society. I took things for granted, yes, but my life was not one of them. Besides I was a lowly sartor, who walked amongst the great thinkers not seen, nor heard. Those great minds that without question, showed continuous ignorance with their forced opinions and decisions. Looking back maybe I rejected faith and religion, yes even God because it wasn't a choice, but a given that had to be followed or death was bestowed upon you.

You people take choice and act as if it is a right; I guess my time fought for this choice you take so lightly. In my time to even be considered a citizen you accepted the Catholic Church or you were lower then nothing, if that is possible. See I do have a sense of humor, just not that much and soon you will see why. To be an official or even citizen you accepted whatever the Church stated. All these different fashions of faith did not exist in the eyes of the Church. They were secret societies the Church set out to destroy. I'm sorry, cleanse. The cleansing usually meant death but we won't squabble over a play on words. How glorious my life would have been to practice freely the exploration of life's secrets, instead of cowering in the cellar experimenting with the constant fear of exposure. I think I would have been a great scientist in your day. But, I digress. This is not important to the story I wish to tell.

The day started like any other day, at the cock's crow. Our town Constable

entered my shop looking for his new suit to wear at the arrival of the ship the Epiphany bound from England. It carried the new charter for our township sent down from the king himself. A distant relative of the king personally, Charles Bessemer, walked with a confidence of royalty and all were beneath him.

"Good day Master Morrow. How fare you this day and your task at hand?" he asked. "Quite well, your timing is impeccable as always." I replied. "These are ready as we speak. Please try them on." "You are by far the best tailor in the providence," he began, "and is it one of a kind?" "Why yes, I replied thinking; 'I am the only sartor in the providence you pompous arse.' "You know the new charter arrives today? We will be taking on new territory and teaching those heathens the good works. I must look my absolute best." he continued. 'Your absolute best,' my clothes truly are the finest in the land but miracles are not my department, I thought to myself; and as far as those heathens; we would not have lasted one day if it were not for the kindness they gave. The poor fools, they had no idea what they would have to endure over time nor did I. But, the shaman slash witch doctor as we called him in those days had taken a great liking to me, and although outwardly I was social to fit in, he truly was the only person I enjoyed company with, again I remind you in secret.

"You will be joining us at the docks today, Master Morrow?" he spoke with a stern look, his brow slightly raised. "How could I miss such a historical event as this." I replied. Under normal circumstances I cared not for the gatherings choosing when to make an appearance and when not to, but today I was strangely drawn to this event as if my destiny depended on it.

He proceeded to take the garments from my hand and walked to the changing room. He began to speak about his expectations and how this day would change the lives of the citizens for ever. For once I agreed but as he went on my mind drifted out to the bay and I began in my mind to see visions of the ships arrival. "Master Morrow, Master Morrow," he tapped me and brought me back. "Master Morrow," "yes," I snapped back, quickly catching myself and apologizing, "my mind was deep in thought, forgive me," I answer. "A wondering mind, Master Morrow, allows for the devil to partake in your life." He said again with that pompous stare. "Of course, you are right Constable Bessemer, but it was not the devil in my thoughts, but rather the anticipation of the grand acceptance speech you will be giving to day." He began to chuckle, "Good choice of words, Master Morrow, yes it will be grand. The clothes meet your usual standards of excellence. I am pleased. The customary amount is due you," as he reached into his money pouch. "No,

no, consider it my small contribution to history." I replied pushing his hand back. "Fine, what a wonderful gesture of nobility Master Morrow. Good day." As he walked out my smile turned to disgruntlement. I had worked night and day for a week with my best material and I just gave it away. Could have been my sub-conscious fear of his reference to the devil and what I did do in my free time that made me do such a thing. No matter what was done was done and I myself needed to prepare for my destiny.

The Epiphany was due to arrive at the sun's peak of the day. Whilst I prepared my heart raced with anticipation faster and faster as the time drew near. Finally I was ready and as I left out of my shop and turned I was nearly knocked down by a little boy running by. "Master Williams, careful you nearly knocked me over in your haste." "I am sorry Master Morrow, the ship, the ship draws near." Before I could speak he shot off like a cannon ball and as I glanced up I could see the haste in all headed for the bay.

I worked my way through the crowd with the usual niceties and acknowledgements. There she was, one of the king's finest ships before me in all her grandeur. The passengers started to come down the ramp and then I saw her. If ever I doubted there was a God, the proof stood at the top of the plank, the sun glistening behind her causing a heavenly glow around her. Where my heart had been racing, it came to a sudden halt as did time. That moment, that vision, forever captured in my heart. As she proceeded down the ramp I felt our eyes lock. It wasn't until later that I recalled Constable Bessemer greeting her party and accompanying them down the plank. As she walked by her handkerchief fell and I caught it before it hit the ground. "Your handkerchief my lady," I bowed. "Why thank you," she softly spoke while extending her laced gloved hand as she began to curtsy. I eagerly began to reach for her hand, a harsh break in the moment bellowed out. "Come along Bethany, don't keep me waiting!" A round, to say the least elderly lady stood with a sunning umbrella over her head. 'My how much fabric it must take to cover her,' I thought to my self. The young angel that stood before hurried to catch up, her discontentment displayed on her elegant face. 'Bethany,' I sighed.

We met at the town square for the presentation of the charter and the usual displayed acceptances went out. I cared only about one thing, the lovely creature that sat on the stage somewhat behind everyone. The position of her placement showed me she must have been a servant of some kind. Good! Hierarchy and their protocols would have been difficult for a lowly sartor, but a servant, this I could do. Yes, there was hope.

As the gala broke up, I was sharply brought back from my daydreaming to

remember I had a rendezvous to prepare for. We gather for the after ceremony dinner and a feast had been prepared. But our special guests ate privately, so there really was no reason for me to stay, between my new found love and tonight's meeting I was like an eager child filled with anticipation of what life would bring.

Finally dinner was over and we parted company to return to our own lives. Our township sat on, what I accidentally discovered while digging to expand my cellar for wine, caves. These caves were vast and lead to various locations in a five mile radius. I had spent months mapping them out when I had first arrived here; constantly worried that someone else would discover them. Why, I really don't know curiosity was taboo to begin with and caves were the dens where Satan's minions dwelled, this included our heathen friends. What an oxymoronic statement 'heathen friends', so often we contradict our self for self gratification. Anyway, tonight I was to meet my shaman friend for another lesson in herbal logic. I fancied myself on what is now called botany, going with him and learning his foreign tongue and the names they had been given. The winery I had built in my cellar served as a hidden entrance to my laboratory and the entrance to my labyrinth of caves. Every plant had a name and a purpose in this mystical man's arsenal of medicine. Yes I said medicine. I discovered this on one of my many visits with him.

A native boy had been sent out for his first hunt after his rite of passage. You know like the Hebrew have their bar mitzvah. Anyway, contrary to belief they aren't just sent out with a spear and bow and arrows. There is a keeper that secretly watches their every move with the strictest guidelines not to interfere unless it is absolutely necessary. In this particular case it was. The boy had taken on a bear, he had slain the bear but his injuries were great. His keeper brought him back to the village near death. The shaman allowed me to accompany him on his collecting of certain plants to heal the boy. While the others carried on their normal ritual of prayer, yes damn you prayer, he worked feverishly to heal the boy's wounds mashing and mixing all the ingredients we had gathered. Think for a second, what do you think the basis of all those pharmaceuticals is, the valium you pop to sleep, the pills for your headaches, the antibiotics for your countless diseases, which these people had not truly known before we introduced it to them with our nasty little habits. Forget your Hollywood ideas of half naked dark-skin men dancing around the fire and praying to idol gods. We used the word God as the ultimate sign of respect that there is one greater than us. They believed that all life deserved this respect and gave homage, if you will to the first of

every beings kind. We referred to this man and his unique chosen kind as witch doctors, doctor being the key word; revered for his wisdom, like King Author and his people revered the greatest wizard to date, Merlin.

I saw the wounds and felt this was an absolute waste of time but eagerly awaited the proof of my own demented views. Days went by and I secretly returned to see the condition of the boy, to my surprise, progress. Once the boy was beginning to get better we again went in search of herbs to close the wounds faster and prevent infection. Over time the wounds healed with little to no scarring. Amazed, I began to set up my laboratory and collect herbs on my own, experimenting with the wild life, it was easy after he taught me the combination of an anesthetic if you will to keep them quiet and at bay.

Tonight, though, would be a milestone in my life. The shaman took me back to the village where I quickly grasp a special ceremony was to begin and I was being allowed to watch it. The shaman was going to choose his successor for the tribe. What an honor, I could not wait to see who he would choose. I had not really been there in the day time to see him training another to take over. Who could it be?

As the ceremony went on, the women went back and forth out f his tee-pee, the food and drink flowed, and so did the ceremonial peace pipe, I had smoked with the shaman before but this blend of tobacco I am sure I had never tried. It made me feel nostalgic and a sense of belonging I had never felt.

The moment had come; all focus was on the entrance of the tee-pee. It opened and the women came out carrying the tradition garment made for the new shaman. Being a sartor myself I had learned a great deal about their clothing and had even stolen some of their techniques for my business.

With two shaman staffs in his hands he stood with his back to us in front of the fire and began to chant the ceremonial words. After some time the once star lit clear sky grew dark and cloudy, and he turned. He told me to stand, caught up if you will in what I was watching I was unaware that the women stood behind me the whole time. I stood as he handed me the staff and they placed the garment over my shoulders. Just then lighting struck the massive tree in front of us and then there was darkness.

I awoke the next morning with a persistent banging at my door; still dressed from the night before, I shed my shaman robe to the floor and went downstairs to answer the shop door. As I began to open the door, there my angel stood as before with the sun's aura illuminating around her. She was quickly eclipsed by that large woman. "Thou are Sartor Morrow?" she

bellowed out. "Yes," answering but not paying her really any mind. "I am Lady Gortilia Everstone, this is my husband Thurston Everstone," noticing I was staring at the young lady slightly to her side yet behind her, she continued, "This is Bethany Summerfield, my **hand woman**." She spoke as she moved to my display of fabrics. I took Bethany's glove laced hand to finish what I started at the docks. "Did you not hear me? She is my hand woman," as she pushed her aside with her girth and extended her hand to me. "My lady, how can I be of service to you?" "Better, much better! Thou wills' make my husbands a suit, per request of your Constable." Her demand met no answer; I merely set out on my task of measuring this small frail frame of a man. My movements were natural thank the heavens for I all I really focused on was my new found Summer Field. Afterward they left and I was thankful I was not a **seamstress**; for if this too had to be a donation I would go out of business clothing her. I returned to my room to bathe holding my head in great discomfort and then it hit me. Did I dream last night? No, the evidence laid on the floor before me. How did I get back here? Had anyone seen me or them? What now? I had been living two lives, but now both lives had responsibilities upon me I would have to bare. I sat at the edge of my bed, pondering the possibilities. None the less I AM A SHAMAN! My people love and revere me. I am not just a lowly sartor and no one here can ever know. 'Aaahhh Bethany', I whispered as I pulled the quilt over my head. Today was a day to reflect, contemplate, yes to rest.

Thankfully, I did get compensation for my efforts and became the Everstone's official sartor, Mr. Everstone and his four obnoxious sons. Because of this, all the new colonists that were of wealth came only to me and the two sartor that had come over went else where to make their fortune. Most of all I saw Bethany often and our courtship began with Lady Everstone's blessing. My existence was perfect, work and Bethany by day, my secret studies at night. Eventually I would have to explain things to Bethany, or would I?

Bethany started to hint about matrimony as did others. I conveniently avoided the subject. As the season's change so to did all the gala events and work slowed. This meant I could concentrate more on my personal work and my tribe. The kindness and understand of the tribe was like no other; for I had to be one way with them by day and another at night. The shaman explained to our people this society's heathen ways, and the many faces that had to be worn to exist freely amongst them.

The challenges of my experiments grew as the 'doctor' of the township began to deal with sickness and hardships that fell upon the people. Being of some stature now I moved freely collecting sample of things in my own unique way and bringing them to my laboratory, ever so careful not to bring them around the tribe. The shaman's sterilization processes were amazing in comparison to the knowledge the good doctor had, and I must admit having this knowledge and seeing his barbaric ways made me speak out at times, but I quickly, after strange glares and comments, would remember my place here and excuse myself apologetically. I would volunteer to sit with those sickly individuals and the medicines I made, I secretly administered however necessary that the situation called for. Of course our good doctor took all the credit.

It was going into heavy winter and I was summoned to the Everstone's mansion to make special suits for the boys. I went about my normal tasks, and as I was leaving went to find my darling Bethany. As I approached the servant area of the house I began to hear crying and a whip cracking. I positioned myself to see Thurston with a whip in his hand and someone strung up. "Again Thurston, thou are not truly cleansing the poor child, yet." "Yes, my beloved." "Children tighten the coils around her arms, she squirming too much." "Yes mama." They said with laughter. "No more my lady, I beg thee." That voice, those cries, my God Bethany! How could I have been so blind; all of her persistence to marry, all her dreadful looks when we would part, the constant gloves on her hands? I stumbled back and nearly knocked over a vase. I ran out into the snow storm that had begun barely noticing it.

I escaped into my laboratory. It seemed we both had our secrets, I allowing mine to shield me from seeing hers and her suffering. Just then one of my experimental animals cried out. You see one of the children recently had contracted a disease that formed puss like raises on the skin. It covered his entire body. I obtained a sample and had infected several animals with this and with the knowledge of shamanisms had successfully cured them. I secretly put the antidote in his food when I sat with him voluntarily.

I still had my samples. But the suffering that little boy went through would not be enough. No the Everstones' would have to suffer the humiliation of disfigurement, the pain of torture. They would have to walk amongst their piers and be looked upon with disgust. I would dedicate all of my time with making them pay. Close the shop; say I was going away on a trip for a special order. Yes, that would work. But Bethany, my sweet Bethany, I had to face reality. There was no telling how long she had been tortured by these

monsters. However, when I was done all would know and see them as the vile creatures they were and then I would rescue her from her persecution and we would leave this place and start a new. Thanks to the Everstones I had amassed quite a large amount of gold, even with the gold given to my tribe for supplies. Yes, she would have her own servants, but first they must pay.

I set my plan into action, Bethany was the hardest to say goodbye to, now knowing her secret made it that much harder. But, this was for her, our future, one day I would tell of the sacrifice, maybe. I took my entire spectrum of sample, herbs and knowledge and began combining them, cutting myself off from even the tribe; telling them to stay away from me for a while. You see the shaman I could not consciously lie to and besides he would know the truth. Better to excommunicate my self then lie to the only person who truly saw me as an equal, a friend.

I isolated my test subjects away from the rest of the animals I had collected, far away. I studied the break down of their tissues and watched them suffer terribly. My one consolation it soon would be the Everstones. The day came I was ready to return, it was time to leave my dungeon and return to the world for my revenge, my new disease ready to be administered. My front door had orders galore of outfit ideas and requests, but first Bethany. I will not bore you with detail of the niceties and jubilations of my return, or how my heart became flooded when I saw my Bethany as if for the first time.

To my surprise I truly was missed and the Constable and the Everstones through a huge dinner party on my behalf. This would be my chance.

Unbeknownst to me relationships with my tribe had also flourished, and trade between the township and my tribe was prosperous; so the heads of the tribe were also invited. I would have never foreseen this. But my anger with isolation had grown, and at that time I saw nothing but revenge. The party ended the deed done; all that was left was to wait.

Back to work I went and it took no time to see the signs of my work, my lab created monster, only it was not isolated in just the Everstones. I had only administered it in their specific food, no one else's. The first to show signs was little Master Williams. I raced to my laboratory, praying only those I had infected would have it. To my horror, they had died, even with the antidote I had given to reverse the affects. I was so sure I had total control. All the animals either were diseased or had already died, as far as three mile away from the actual original start or what is referred to as ground zero. I stood by and watched the original Chesapeake Bay, my tribe, my Bethany die. I am the originator of smallpox. A barren, lifeless, wasteland is what the original

Chesapeake Bay became; leaving me an immortal forced to walk this earth and see man repeat the same abominations in various ways over and over again. A keeper only intervening when totally necessary to keep life moving until God finally calls me and ends my suffering. Remember I stated I believed in science not faith in religion, but I learned way back then from my true brothers, humans' depraved sense of humor like everything else must originate from some where. There has to be a first, this is my GOD.

Inspiration

Good morning my love.

Close your eyes and listen to my voice as I tell you of the dreams your love inspires.

To love you is to love life, for life is one of the things you are full of.

To make love to you is to make love to a real woman whose love for me at that time she cannot deny.

You say you have a furious love that you will unleash upon me from ever wanting another.

God only knows how I long for this day, for I feel once you do; the love I have for you and will give in return, will make you for ever stay.

'Tis true the love making we've shared that burns in your passions right now, are sweet indeed.

But can't compare to the passion I would unleash upon you if only you were mine and no others.

This I swear.

So the dream in my heart is the Christmas present I will give, unlocking the passion you have to 'rock my very world'.

So if you do come for Christmas and this fantasy is fulfilled, then the new year you will have only one man, one love, one friend, and one future.

I promise you will never look back and want to change your decision ever again.